brought such pain and penury to Kashmir's gentle people that some of them went to Punjab to appeal to its Sikh Maharaja Ranjit Singh to come to Srinagar to save them. But one-eyed Ranjit proved little better than his Muslim precursors in dealing with Kashmir's population. He was, however, strong and shrewd enough to keep the British Company Raj at bay. But, after his death in 1839, Dogra Rajput Gulab Singh turned against the Sikhs he had earlier served and helped British troops seize control of the valley.

Gulab Singh later bought Kashmir from the British for a nominal sum, and, having earlier received Jammu from Ranjit Singh, he combined them into the largest of British India's six hundred princely states, Jammu and Kashmir, which in 1846 the British turned over to Gulab Singh and his male heirs in perpetuity. Gulab's son, Ranbir Singh, proved as helpful to his British overlords as his father had been, sending Kashmiri troops and guns to Delhi in 1858 to oust Bengal's Sepoy mutineers from that Mughal capital. Ranbir was given Britain's full twenty-one-gun salute status at the top of India's princely pecking order. Devout Hindu that he was, he funded the building of many new temples in Jammu, employing all of his Dogra relatives and Kashmir's Hindu pandits but leaving his Muslim subjects impoverished and dissatisfied. After Ranbir died in 1885, his son Pratap Singh inherited Kashmir, which he ruled till his own death in 1925. He died without heir but was succeeded by his nephew Hari Singh, who most enjoyed visiting London, where he soon learned of the attractions of Soho and Kensington, focusing more time and attention on women than on the plight of his poor Kashmiri people. Mountbatten had early befriended Hari Singh, and helped keep his name out of London's tabloid press in a notorious scandal where he was known only as "Mr. A."

In mid-August 1947, Viceroy Lord Mountbatten had no hesitation about leaving the destiny of Kashmir's four million subjects, 77 percent of whom were Muslims, to the personal choice of Maharaja Hari Singh. Only Hari could not make up his mind, fearing the socialist Nehru's India almost as much as he did the prospect of joining Jinnah's Pakistan. He hoped instead to keep Jammu and Kashmir independent, the Switzerland of Asia. That dream was never accepted as feasible by either India or Pakistan. Kashmir's beauty, strategic value, and ethnic complexity may resemble Switzerland's, but neither of its powerful neighbors was willing to indulge Hari Singh's fantasy or to wait very long for him to decide which dominion to join.